Punjab, the army has projected the idea that a national consensus exists regarding the issue. Moreover, it has used the pretext of a consensus about Kashmir's importance as a means of retaining influence over national politics.[21]

Stephen Cohen, an American scholar who has written extensively on the subject, posits that three distinct generations joined the Pakistan army through 1982: a British generation; an American generation; and a Pakistani generation. The men comprising this third generation had less exposure to Western influences.[22] Many of those who constituted this third generation of Pakistani soldier also came from the lower middle class. Some of these men, who shared similar backgrounds with Lashkar recruits, were more susceptible to Zia's Islamization.[23]

This does not mean the Pakistan army is an Islamist one. To the degree that the army is associated with Islam it is in the communal form, i.e. in opposition to Hindu India as opposed to a universal or pan-Islamist conception.[24] However, the army has used pan-Islamic sentiment as pretext for projecting power beyond Pakistan's borders. Recourse to this latter path expanded as Pakistan sought to extend its influence into Afghanistan and Kashmir. Jihadi groups became ready allies of the Pakistan army's efforts to attain strategic depth in Afghanistan and to bleed India via the Kashmir jihad. It is important to stress that these groups were used for nationalist purposes and that the army remains a nationalist—not an Islamist—organization. Nevertheless, the relationship between the military and its militant proxies was not a 'one-way street.'[25] Soldiers and civilian jihadis fought side-by-side in Afghanistan against the Soviets, and the two co-operated closely in Indian-administered Kashmir as well. Some soldiers were affected by this collaboration, and no doubt came to admire their civilian militant counterparts. Those espousing extreme views—of any variety—generally have not advanced to the upper military echelons.[26] The record is more mixed among mid-ranking officials, some of whom have embraced the ideological precepts for which their proxies fought.

This is also true among those seconded to the military's Inter-Services Intelligence Directorate [ISI]. Major General William Cawthorne, a British officer who served as the Pakistan army's deputy chief of staff following Partition, created the ISI to increase intelligence and military cooperation. It is one of two military intelligence services in Pakistan, the other being